Chapter Nineteen

Foreign Relations

Between 1157 and 1168, the emperor of Byzantium expands his borders and inadvertently sets Serbia free

In 1157, the Great Seljuk of the Turks died, broken.

Ahmed Sanjar had begun his reign as supreme Turkish sultan with a huge realm under his hands, the largest a Muslim ruler had held since the days of the old Abbasid caliphate.* By the end of his life, he had lost the Ghurids, who were busy plundering the eastern reaches of the lands he had once ruled; he had been driven out of his lands Transoxania (east of the Oxus river) by nomadic Chinese tribes called the Western Liao; Nur ad-Din, theoretically owing him allegiance, was doing as he pleased in the Mediterranean lands. At the very end of his life, Sanjar had tried to put down a native revolt in Khorasan itself and had failed so badly that the rebels had actually taken him captive and pillaged his capital city of Merv. His greatest achievement had been to build himself a gorgeous mausoleum in the city of Merv, where he was now laid to rest.[1]

He was the last Great Seljuk. No one else even tried to claim that the Turkish lands were a unity. Khorasan became a no-man's-land, and from the Oxus to the Mediterranean shore, each Turkish sultan looked out for his own interests.[2]

This changed the landscape for the Byzantine emperor. The First Crusade